

pened during the Sassanian age does not concern us. I should, however, remind those who read detailed comparisons in the work of Bousset or Böklen that the antiquity of material to be found in the Pahlavi books is subject to the greatest uncertainty. We may be dealing with faithfully produced translations of old Avestan texts now lost, or with doctrines of medieval post-Sassanian Parsism. When we add to this the problems of date presented by the material collected in the Talmud, it is clear that the question of interlacing dependence is likely to be often insoluble. Happily, I am able to pass it by, and go back to Babylon as the place of contact, according to Bousset, the most important champion of the theory of Iranian influence on Judaism. It may be well to quote his summary (*Judentum*, p. 548):

The place where Parsism and Judaism came in contact was Babylon and the Babylonian plain. In Babylon, as we have said, was the centre of Jewish religion after the Exile. And there are many indications that on the other side Iranian religion had overflowed its ancient bounds and pushed its way far into the west, and in any case had attained the predominance in the old Babylonian mother-country. When Alexander the Great made his expedition to Babylon, there met him in the front rank the "Magi" or Persian priests, and in the second the Chaldæans, the priests of the Babylonian religion.¹ In Greek tradition

¹ Bousset quotes Quintus Curtius, who gives us the order of the procession which met Alexander when he entered Babylon after Arbela. After the captain of the citadel and the presents he brought came the Magi:—Magi deinde suo more carmen canentes, post hos Chaldaei Babyloniorumque non vates modo, sed etiam artifices cum fidibus sui generis ibant, laudes hi regum canere soliti, Chaldaei siderum motus et statas vices temporum ostendere. So

Zarathushtra (Zoroaster, Zaratus, etc.) often figures as an Assyrian or a Babylonian. This means that Greek scholars travelling in the East found the Zarathushtrian religion predominant in the Babylonian plain. In Jewish-Christian tradition the legendary ruler of Babylon, Nimrod, was identified with Zoroaster. Iranian religion pushed yet further westwards during the period with which we are concerned, in the form of Mithraism, which was very closely related and sprang from the same roots. Antiochus of Commagene, in the first half of the first century B.C., was a Mithraist, as we learn with certainty from his famous epitaph. The religion of the pirates conquered by Pompey, who came mostly from Cilicia and Cyprus, must also have been Mithraism. Contacts between Judaism and Iranian religion were abundant during the last centuries B.C. It may further be noted that the relations of Judaism to the Persian empire were from the first very friendly. To the Persians Judaism largely owed its restoration. And in the following centuries it appears to have remained altogether unmolested within that empire, and with complete freedom of development.

again in III. 39. 10, Darius sets out for Issus with Magi who come second after the sacred fire, followed by 365 youths "puniceis amiculis velati, diebus totius anni pares numero." My colleague Prof. Tait notes for me the limitations of Curtius, who depended too much on the rhetorical writers of the century after Alexander: unless supported by Arrian, who had narratives written by Alexander's generals, his facts are usually viewed with some distrust. Here one may say there is nothing improbable, though we cannot prove that the description represents conditions older than the age of the historian. I may observe that the detail about the 365 youths is simply Mithraic: cf. Jerome, *In Amos*, v. 9-10 (ap. Cumont, *Textes*, ii. 19), where it is said that Basilides made 'Αβράξας supreme god, meaning thereby the course of the year, "quem ethnici sub eodem nomine aliarum litterarum vocant Μείθρας." (Μείθρας and 'Αβράξας alike have letters whose numerical value totals 365.) Prof. Jackson holds that Curtius has "much that is truly Persian," and would not rule out the 365 youths as standing for the solar year.

The page which follows this has been quoted already (p. 288 f.). The importance of Prof. Bousset's views on the subject is so great that I make no apology for completing my transcript of his summary. He proceeds in conclusion (p. 550):

One point, however, must be emphasised very specially here. Judaism came in contact with Persian religion, as we have already explained, primarily in Babylon. We shall have to conclude, therefore, that the Jews learnt to know this religion not in its purity but when strongly tainted with Babylonian elements. This mixture of Babylonian and Persian religion must in general be regarded among the most important facts of the history of religious syncretism during the last centuries B.C. It must also have been highly significant for the development of Judaism. We must also conclude that Babylonian religion in many respects influenced that of the Jews through the medium of Parsism, even where a direct contact is not admissible. The origin of many ideas which were influential in Judaism cannot accordingly be defined with certainty; and we must be content to speak ultimately in general terms of "foreign Oriental elements."

The admission of Prof. Bousset that Parsi influence on Judaism must be restricted to the period of syncretism and decadence in Parsism has very great significance for our problem. Practically it means that Zarathushtra himself is to be struck out of the list of the prophets who contributed to the development of Israel's religion. All the indications gathered during the course of these Lectures have converged upon a proof that Zarathushtra influenced only a small circle in the West during the period to which I am limiting my inquiry. What was known of his teaching reached the people living in Babylonia and

Media only as the Magi represented it; and the mirror they held was indifferently polished. It will be an advantage if at this point we stop to ask what were the main characteristics of Parsism as it would be understood by Jews living in Babylonia and Media during the last four centuries before Christ. It had lost the very features which bring the Gathas nearest to the spirit of Israel's prophets. Magian dualism and ritualism were firmly established. The Amshaspands, always an esoteric conception, had not begun to take their place beside the Yazatas of popular worship.¹ The Magi had popularised the aristocratic divinity Ahura Mazdah, and set by his side the foreign Anahita and the Aryan but now syncretised Mithra. A host of angels and an antithetic host of demons occupied a prominent place in the creed. Religious duties included the slaying of (theoretically) noxious animals, the performance of tedious ceremonial such as we find in large measure in the Vendidad, and the pronouncing of sacred formulæ as the most powerful of spells. With the ascendancy of the Magi came the commendation of next-of-kin marriages, with which the religion was necessarily credited, although these alien priests failed in their long struggle to get them established as orthodox. And the idea of immortality must have declined very much from its strongly ethical character. So far as the Magi took it up at all, it was only as a part of their mechanically balanced reconstruction: death must disappear in the new world just as mountains and shadows and dialects and other unsymmetrical things. As for Zarathushtra, the Magi claimed him as one of them-

¹ Except in name: see p. 100 f.

selves,¹ a great figure of mythical attributes, a master of magic and esoteric lore. This picture, drawn from the evidence supplied primarily by the classical writers,² may be used when we ask how much the Jews are likely to have taken from Parsism. If the Parsism they knew was after this model, certainly there was not much by which they could enrich their own religious treasury.

The Talmud states that the Jews "brought the names of the angels from Babylon," which tallies with the obvious contrast between the pre-exilic angelology and the detailed and ordered hierarchies of later Judaism. This elaborated doctrine of angels and spirits was an unmistakably new thing, as is shown by the refusal of the conservative Sadducees to accept it.³ I see no *a priori* reason for denying the possibility that Persian (that is, Magian) influence fostered the growth of this quasi-animistic angelology. It was never in the main stream of Jewish theology. Paul's attitude towards it is very suggestive. Meeting something essentially of the same kind at Colossæ, he took no trouble to endorse or deny its truth. Speculation about angels was for him purely idle, and worship of angels debased superstition: the only

¹ Rightly, as Prof. Jackson still thinks. On this subject see my remarks above, p. 197 f.

² "But I believe it to be fairly true, if you compare the Muhammadan writers of later times," writes Prof. Jackson. Does not their date alone make testimony on such matters almost valueless? But I need not repeat with how much diffidence I venture a view of Zarathushtra and the Magi which differs seriously from that of such an authority as my friend. I have stated my reasons elsewhere, and must leave my theories to sink or swim.

³ Acts 23⁸.

thing that mattered was our direct relations with a Being infinitely high above all angelic hosts. If we are concerned with the question whether the later Judaism developed its own new world of spirits, or derived it wholly or partially from an external source, it seems enough to say that there was a system not unlike their own in the environment of the Jews of the post-exilic period ; and that, if the specialists in Old Testament theology find the later developments inexplicable by native growth, there is a possible *vera causa* in Magianism. I do not presume to decide the question, and I confess it seems to me to have singularly little importance.

One kind of "angel" who plays a small but not trifling part in Jewish angelology is very much like the Fravashi or "double," which formed the subject of Lecture VIII. Is there dependence here? The link would be easy to make, for, as we have seen, the Fravashi concept on both its sides is no part of Zaratrustra's system, but belongs partly to the ancestor-worship of primitive Aryan religion, and partly to a belief in a kind of External Soul, which may belong to Iranian or to Magian doctrine. This had its home in the countries which Jews knew well during the Exile. The conception accounts primarily for Matt. 18¹⁰ and Acts 12¹⁵. The "angel" of the little child, who has not learned to sin, stands in the very presence of God. Jesus then gives emphatic endorsement to an idea the history of which may have started far away. And the company in Mary's house are ready to assume that the "double" of the Apostle for whom they had met to pray was standing outside the door. These two passages seem to be explicable

by the presence of a belief in angels very much like the Fravashis on the side which was independent of ancestor-worship. The same may be said of the "princes" of the nations in Daniel and the Talmud, and the "angels of the Churches" in Rev. 2-3. These Fravashis of communities answer very well to Avestan conceptions. Inasmuch as there seems to be nothing in Israel's native angelology to prompt such a development, it is not unreasonable to suspect a real foreign influence here.¹

Much more serious is the question whether foreign influence affected Jewish demonology. Here I put on one side the popular belief by which demons took in relation to disease very much the position that microbes take for us.² There is no reason for recognising Persian influence of any kind here, though there are some similarities in Persian as in other religious systems. What concerns me more is the possibility that the Magian Ahriman explains the Jewish Satan. It is fairly pointed out that the idea of attributing evil, moral as well as physical, to the agency of a spirit antagonistic to God is late in Jewish thought. One thinks at once of the Chronicler's assigning to a temptation of Satan what the earlier writer attributed to Yahweh.³ Now if we content ourselves with saying that in post-exilic times the Jews knew of a (Magian) theory whereby evil came from a power hostile to God,

¹ For a discussion of Biblical passages involved, see my paper "It is his Angel" in *Journal of Theological Studies*, 1902, p. 514 ff.: also above, p. 274.

² Prof. Jackson remarks that a Zoroastrian priest said the same to him years ago.

³ 2 Sam. 24¹, 1 Chron. 21¹.

we may account for the phenomena by assuming that it fructified in their minds and helped their thinkers to their solution of the great problem. But the development of the Hebrew Satan is perfectly clear, and wholly different from that of the Magian Ahriman. I have already referred to these differences, and will only now express the belief that a hint was given and used, but used in a wholly original and characteristic way.

A more hopeful field for the discovery of genuine Persian influence lies in Apocalyptic. We have seen that Zarathushtra was really the earliest apocalyptic thinker; and (what is more important for our purpose) he was mostly known to after ages in this character. Now almost the only resemblances that powerfully strike us, by their number and their exactness alike, are found in the imagery of Apocalyptic: not the substance, or the religious ideas that the literature conveys, but the machinery and the formulæ show sometimes a likeness which we cannot easily regard as accidental, the cumulative effect of many coincidences being considered. Several of them affect the Johannine Apocalypse. There is the final unchaining of Aži Dahāka, the Old Serpent, which prepares for his final destruction, and the detail that he swallows the third part of men and beasts:¹ cf. Rev. 20^{2, 7-10}, 8⁷⁻¹², 9¹⁵. Then there is the falling of the great star Gocîhar upon the earth which strongly suggests Rev. 8¹⁰. It may be said, of course, that these are only from the Bundahish, and that there are possibilities of lateness. But, as Prof. Jackson notes, the general antiquity of

¹ Söderblom, *La Vie Future*, p. 258 f. Clemen, *Primitive Christianity*, p. 137 (E.T.).

the Bundahish, as based on the Dâmdât Nask, and confirmed in important respects by Plutarch, justifies us in depending on it: we remember also how independent astronomical tests have assigned it an epoch as early as 40 A.D.¹ An Avestan guarantee is available for the parallel between Yima's *Var* and the Jerusalem of Rev. 21.² More important is the mention in Rev. 1⁴ of "the seven Spirits which are before [God's] throne." This answers closely to the form of the Amshaspand doctrine in which the number seven is made up without including Ahura Mazdah; and it is significant that the same form appears in *Tobit*, which we find to be based largely on Magian folk-story. Extra-canonical works like *Enoch* supply a larger fund of parallels. A quotation from Clemen's summary will put in short compass the points in which an acute outside observer of Parsism thinks the imagery of Jewish-Christian apocalyptic traceable to this outside source:³

The idea of the Son of Man comes ultimately from Parsism,⁴ and the speculation in this system regarding the Primal Man⁵ probably lurks behind such passages as 1 Cor. 15⁴⁵ ff. and Phil. 2⁶ f. But, more important than this, the expectation of a future triumph over the devil,⁶ of a

¹ See above, p. 26 f.

² See p. 308, and *ERPP*, 156.

³ *Primitive Christianity*, 368 (E.T.).

⁴ P. 154-6. None of the evidence is early, and at the most can only affect externals.

⁵ *Ib.* The extent to which Yima and Adam approximate is indicated above.

⁶ P. 160. This point, as far as imagery goes, was admitted above. There is not the slightest reason to assert a historical connexion between the two religions in their optimist outlook as a whole: cf. p. 155 f. above.

universal conflagration, of a new heaven and a new earth, as well as of the destiny of the blessed, agrees so fully with Mazdeism even in details, that here again the influence of this system must be admitted.¹ And so, too, the Mazdean belief, that the soul traverses a series of heavens,² has probably influenced 2 Cor. 12² ff., perhaps also Heb. 4¹⁴, 1 Tim. 3¹⁶, and particularly Jude⁹—just as the Mazdean comparison of the resurrection body with a new heavenly garment has influenced the corresponding passages in Paul's Epistles (2 Cor. 5¹ ff.) and the Apocalypse.³

I might add to these the very ingenious but hardly convincing comparison of Rev. 1¹³ with the "high-girt" Vayu of *Yt* 15⁵⁴ (and Anāhita in *Yt* 5⁶⁴) by Dr James Moffatt (*Expositor's Greek Testament, in loc.*).⁴ How far we may accept Prof. Clemen's comparisons will appear from the notes below. I only remark further that the atmosphere of Jewish and Parsi apocalyptic is sufficiently alike to make us ready to believe in a real connexion. Just as the Jews picked up and adapted an unmistakably Iranian story like *Tobit*, they may very well have used the figures and imagery of Magianism for their national vision-literature. It is far from easy to prove conclusively that they really did so, but

¹ The final conflagration differs in the most important feature of its imagery—where is the *molten metal* in Judaism, except (insignificantly enough) in *Enoch*?

² P. 171 f., depending mainly on Bousset. The three stages of the ascent to *Garōnmāna* in the *Hadhokht Nask* (*Yt* 22¹⁵) are the best evidence of this idea in Parsism. I should not object to it. And yet, was not a Jew bound to be influenced by his own language, in which "heaven" is plural? Must we go further afield?

³ P. 174. But the one Avestan passage quoted (*Ys* 55²) only says that the Gathas are like food and clothing! The Bundahish passage is equally distant from the point.

⁴ Clemen rejects this (p. 154).

it remains on the whole probable. The debt, if acknowledged, is small enough.

The greatest innovation of post-exilic Judaism was, of course, the doctrine of Immortality. Here again the stimulus of Parsism has been freely assumed. But if my thesis is right, the immortality doctrine of Magians in contact with Israel was very different from Zarathushtra's teaching. The bare fact that the Persians believed death would at last be abolished was not a very powerful encouragement to Jewish thinkers in their great venture; though I would not deny that it may have contributed something. The real lesson lies much deeper, and with it we may close, making no attempt to pursue parallels which only become numerous or detailed in a period outside our limits. Zarathushtra's doctrine of Immortality rested on a pure and passionate belief in the justice of God. Successors endowed with his spirit might have developed a serious theology recognising adequately the fact of sin and the need of deliverance. But the successors never came. Zarathushtra is a lonely figure, and the mere fact that Israel has a "goodly fellowship" of prophets to set against his solitariness is quite enough to explain the sequel. We might compare him with individuals in the long line and gladly count him worthy to stand among the greatest of them. But had he stood out above them all, he could not have prepared for the establishment of a world religion. It was Carthage that accounted for the failure of Hannibal: it was Iran that made Zarathushtra a voice of one crying in the wilderness where but few could hear. The interpreters of Zarathushtra busied themselves with

explaining the world where they should have tried to save it;¹ they spent in dreams about its future blessedness the energy that might have produced a diagnosis of its deepest needs, and some contribution towards their satisfaction. The result was a shallow optimism from which any real understanding of Zarathushtra himself might have saved them. The very devil against whom they fought was a poor sort of demon after all, contending with plenty of noise but with no sort of success: he could be conquered by muttering a Gatha and killing some frogs. And Evil is a greater and more fearful fact than anything represented in the Magian Ahriman. The shadows were not dark enough because the light had grown dim since Zarathushtra's day. I am loth to criticise the Magi, for I regard them as worthy of high respect. On a far lower plane than their Prophet, they stand far above most other teachers of their day; and I hope I have made clear the preciousness of their gift when they came to Saoshyant with gold and frankincense and myrrh. Yet at best their myrrh was but an anodyne for a sickness that called for stern surgery. The King of the Jews had no use for it when He came to the supreme task. He promised Paradise with dying breath to a forgiven sinner, and the word came from Persia.² But Persia, even in Zarathushtra's own doctrine, could not fathom the depths of truth

¹ Here again Prof. Jackson would enter a plea for the "energy" of the Magi. He also queries my estimate of Ahriman as an "ineffectual angel" of darkness.

² Av. *pairidaēza* (**περίτοιχος*), "walled enclosure," hence (in Persian) "park." It is curious to compare the conspicuousness of the encircling wall in Milton's picture of Eden.